the relief was evident on my face. My hard work during the recovery had paid off.

It was also an important breakthrough for us in the game and we were able to get into the Australian middle order sooner than expected. Zaheer and Ishant bowled exceptionally well and it was perhaps the best I have seen Zaheer bowl. He was getting the ball to move late and the Australian batsmen struggled against late swing. It's a shame Zaheer suffered so many injuries, otherwise I'm sure we would have seen his match-winning abilities on many more occasions.

We beat the Australians at Mohali by 320 runs and moved to Delhi for the third Test on 29 October leading the four-match contest 1–0. There we managed to keep the momentum going and were happy with a draw, thanks mainly to double hundreds in the first innings by both Gautam Gambhir and Laxman. I scored 68 and felt comfortable enough to believe that a big score wasn't far away; I just had to be patient.

That Delhi Test turned out to be Anil Kumble's last and it was an extremely emotional moment for us all. Anil was one of the biggest match-winners India has produced and we had played together for close to two decades. I was very surprised when he said he was thinking of retiring. He felt he was not bowling close to his best and was not able to give 100 per cent for the team. My argument was simple. Even 80 per cent of Anil Kumble was good enough for most batsmen and India still needed him.

I almost managed to persuade him to carry on but an injury to his spinning finger on the third day of the Test was the final straw. He had just recovered from a shoulder surgery and with the finger injury, which required eleven stitches, he simply couldn't bowl. We carried him on our shoulders and it was a fitting finale for one of international cricket's true all-time greats.

His final speech was very emotional for all of us and the crowd gave him a standing ovation. I'm glad to say we managed to convince Anil to come to Nagpur for the last Test to be a part of the celebration if India went on to win the series. It was only right that Anil should be there, because he had captained us in two of the first three Tests and had also been the captain when we played in Australia earlier in the year.

We started well at Nagpur on 6 November, with an opening partnership of close to a hundred by Sehwag and Vijay, but then lost two quick wickets. I managed to build decent partnerships with Laxman and